

A Framework for Understanding Poverty



by Ruby K. Payne, Ph.D.



Research Module

Based on a 32-year case study
done by Ruby Payne of a
neighborhood of 50–70 people,
98% white.

Research Module

This is a cognitive study—it looks at the *thinking* or mindsets created by environments.

**This is a workshop about
economic diversity,
not racial or cultural
diversity.**

Making a Living in Poverty

- Business
- Government
- Non-Profit
- Drugs/Criminal Behavior

Most people keep the same

mindset

habits

belief systems

UNLESS THEY

develop relationships

get education

Research on poverty can be clustered into five major areas:

Behavior of Individual

Human & Social Capital in
Community

Political & Economic Structures

Exploitation

Environment

Objective for Module One:



**Establish a mental framework
for understanding economic realities.**

1. Poverty is relative (in comparison to others) and is experienced *first* on a very personal level.



Talk to your Neighbor

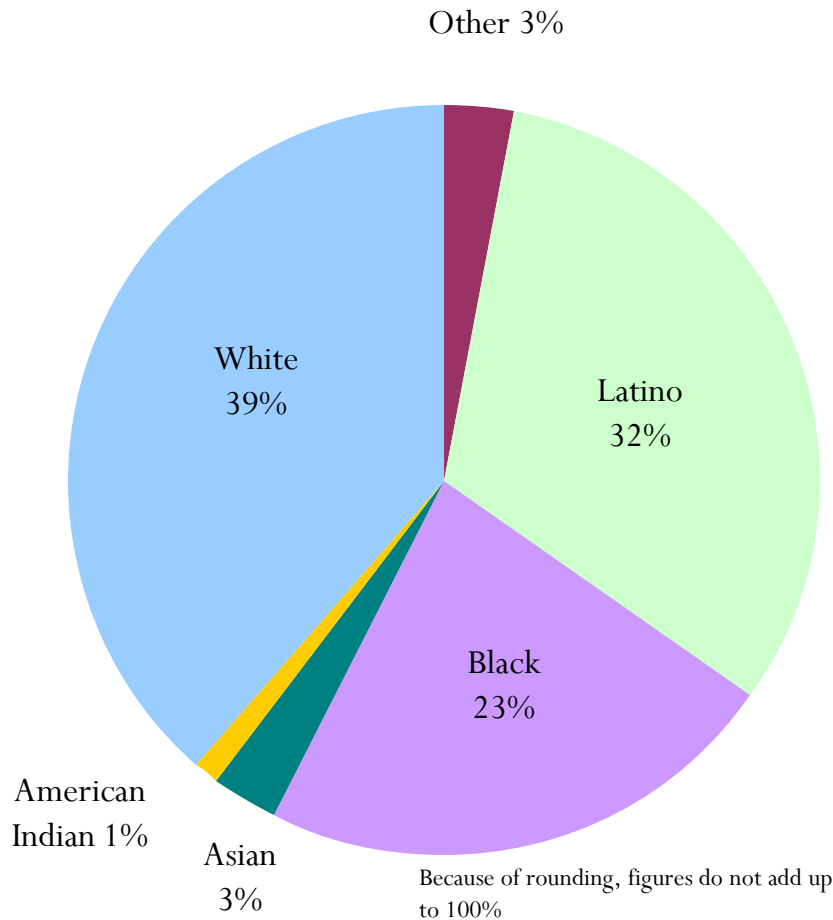


Poverty occurs in all races.

- The greatest number of children in poverty are white, but the greatest percentage is by minority group.
- What minority group has the greatest percentage of children in poverty?

Does the percentage of children in low-income families vary by race/ethnicity?

Children living in low-income families, by race/ethnicity, 2006



- 63% of American Indian children—300,000—live in low-income families.
- 61% of Latino children—9.2 million—live in low-income families.
- 60% of black children—6.5 million—live in low-income families.
- 27% of Asian children—800,000—live in low-income families.
- 26% of white children—11 million—live in low-income families.

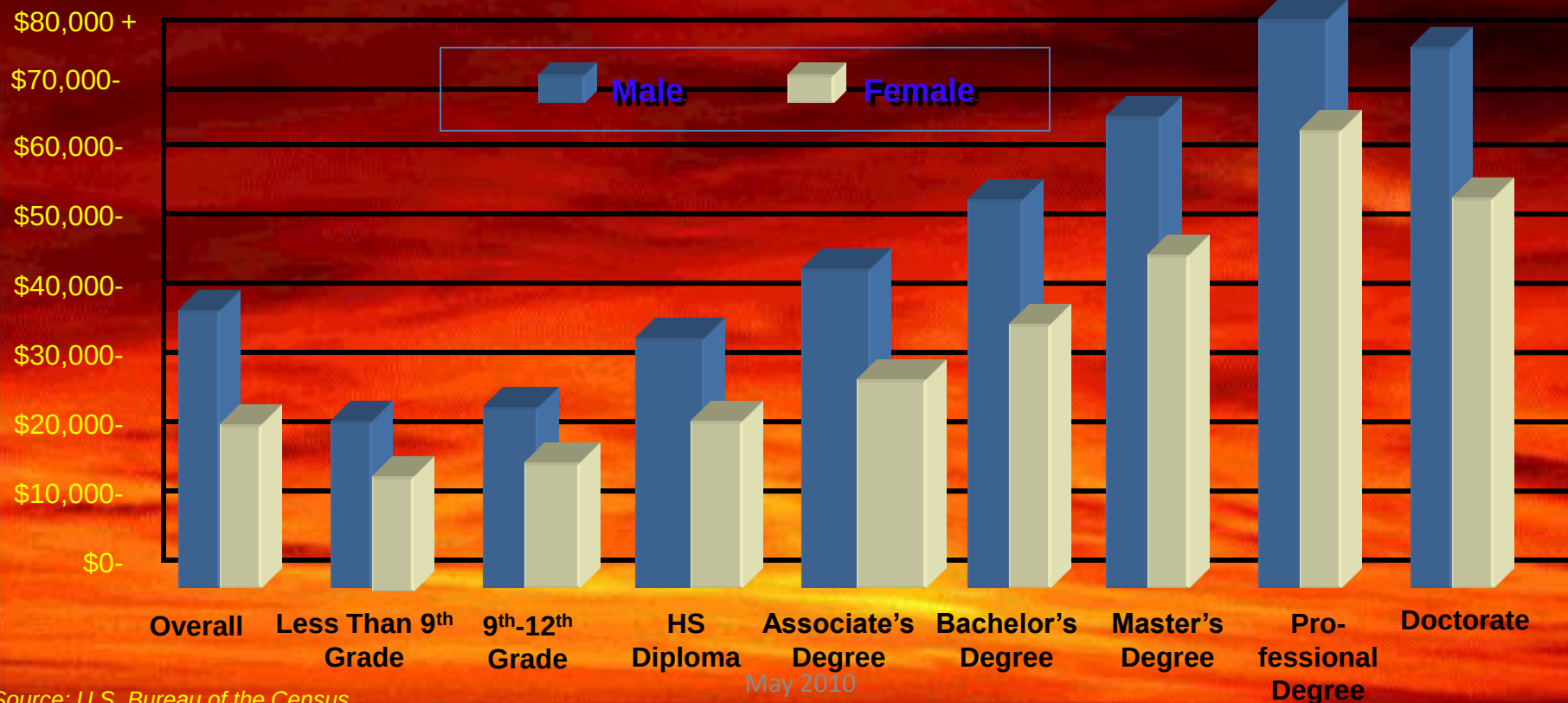
Although American Indian, Latino, and black children are disproportionately low-income, whites comprise the largest group of low-income children.

U.S. Median Income for Persons Age 25 and Older, by Sex and Educational Attainment: 2005

<u>Sex</u>	<u>Overall</u>	<u>Less Than 9th Grade</u>	<u>Grades 9-12 No Diploma</u>	<u>HS Diploma (includes GED)</u>	<u>Associate's Degree</u>	<u>Bachelor's Degree</u>	<u>Master's Degree</u>	<u>Professional Degree</u>	<u>Doctorate</u>
Number of Persons with Income (in thousands)									
Male	70,630	3,277	4,944	21,717	6,088	14,497	5,172	1,635	1,388
Female	61,285	1,593	3,184	17,537	7,066	13,336	5,257	923	649

Median Income, in 2003 Dollars,

Male	\$39,403	\$20,542	\$24,192	\$32,085	\$42,382	\$52,265	\$67,123	\$100,000	\$78,324
Female	\$26,507	\$12,532	\$15,073	\$21,117	\$29,510	\$36,532	\$45,730	\$66,055	\$54,666



5 main reasons for poverty in United States:

- Educational level of adult
- Family structure
- Immigration
- Language issues
- Addiction issues

Pathways out of Poverty

- Education
- Employment
- Health
- Housing
- Nutrition
- Asset development

Source: 2008 Report on Illinois Poverty (www.heartlandalliance.org/maip).

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What is the relationship between health and poverty?

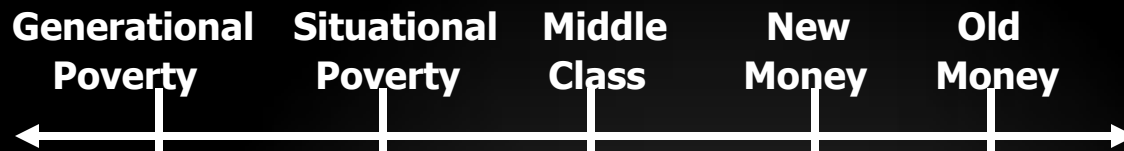
Health Issues
The SES Gradient
(Socioeconomic Status)

- **The richer you are, the healthier you are.**
- **The poorer you are, the sicker you are.**
- **Living in poverty is a risk factor for stress-related illnesses.**
- **It is NOT entirely due to lack of access.**



Source: Robert Sapolsky. *Why Zebras Don't Get Ulcers*. (1998).

2. Generational and situational poverty are different.



Three Generation Rule

It takes three generations in a country as an unskilled immigrant to get college educated.

–Dr. Samuel Betances

Generational Poverty

- **Stays in Poverty**

- Unskilled Workers
- 1st – no high school diploma
- 2nd – no high school diploma; male – physical and/or provider
- 3rd – has less formal language than original generation

- **Gets out of Poverty**

- Workers – values education
- 1st – completes high school
- 2nd – college (teacher, nurse, ...)
- 3rd – advanced degrees (lawyer, doctor ...)

3. This is a cognitive approach to class and is based on patterns of thinking. All patterns have exceptions.

Stereotyping occurs when the patterns of a group are applied to each individual in the group. To do so with this work would be a misuse of the work.



4. Most schools and businesses operate from middle-class norms and values.



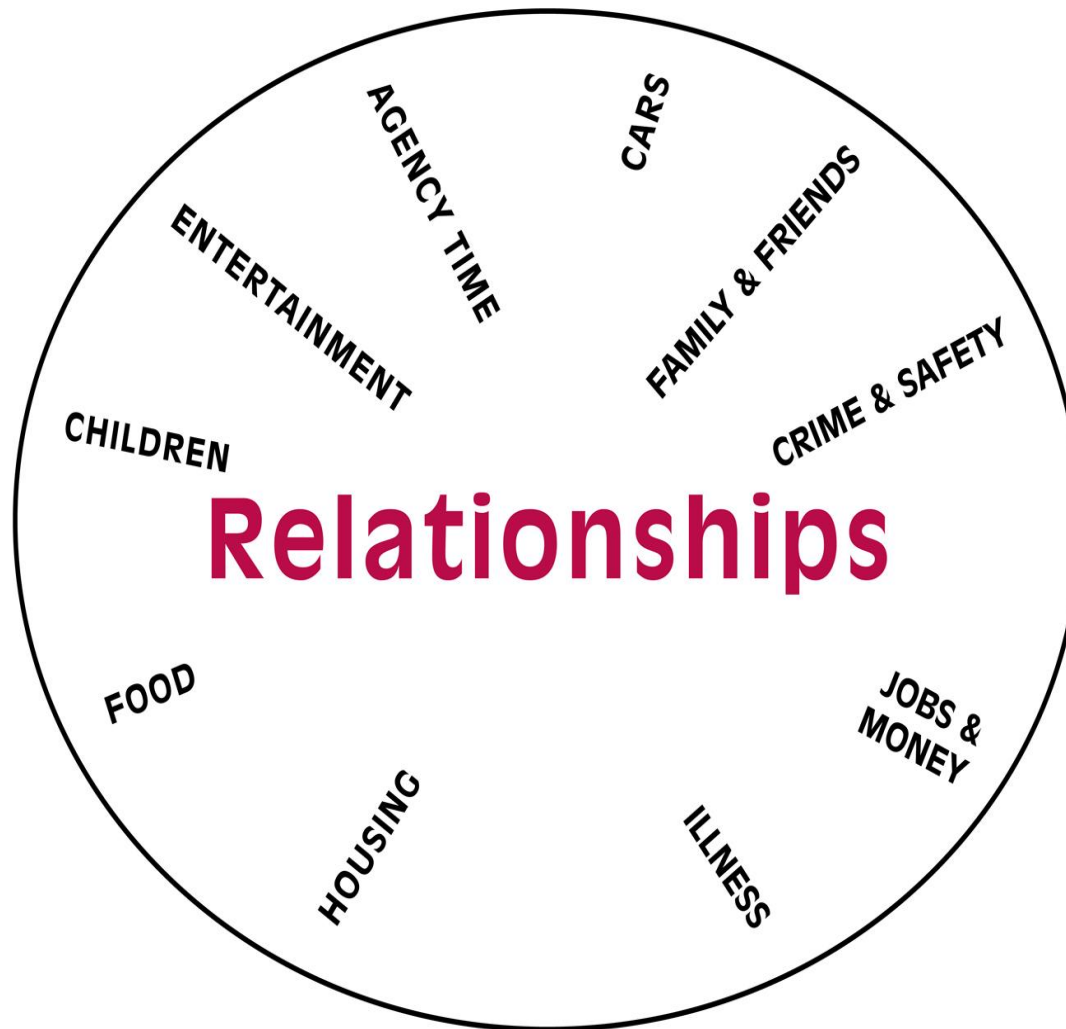
“School starts at 8”

Dr. Rita Pierson

5. Individuals bring with them the hidden rules of the class in which they were raised.



Mental Model for Poverty



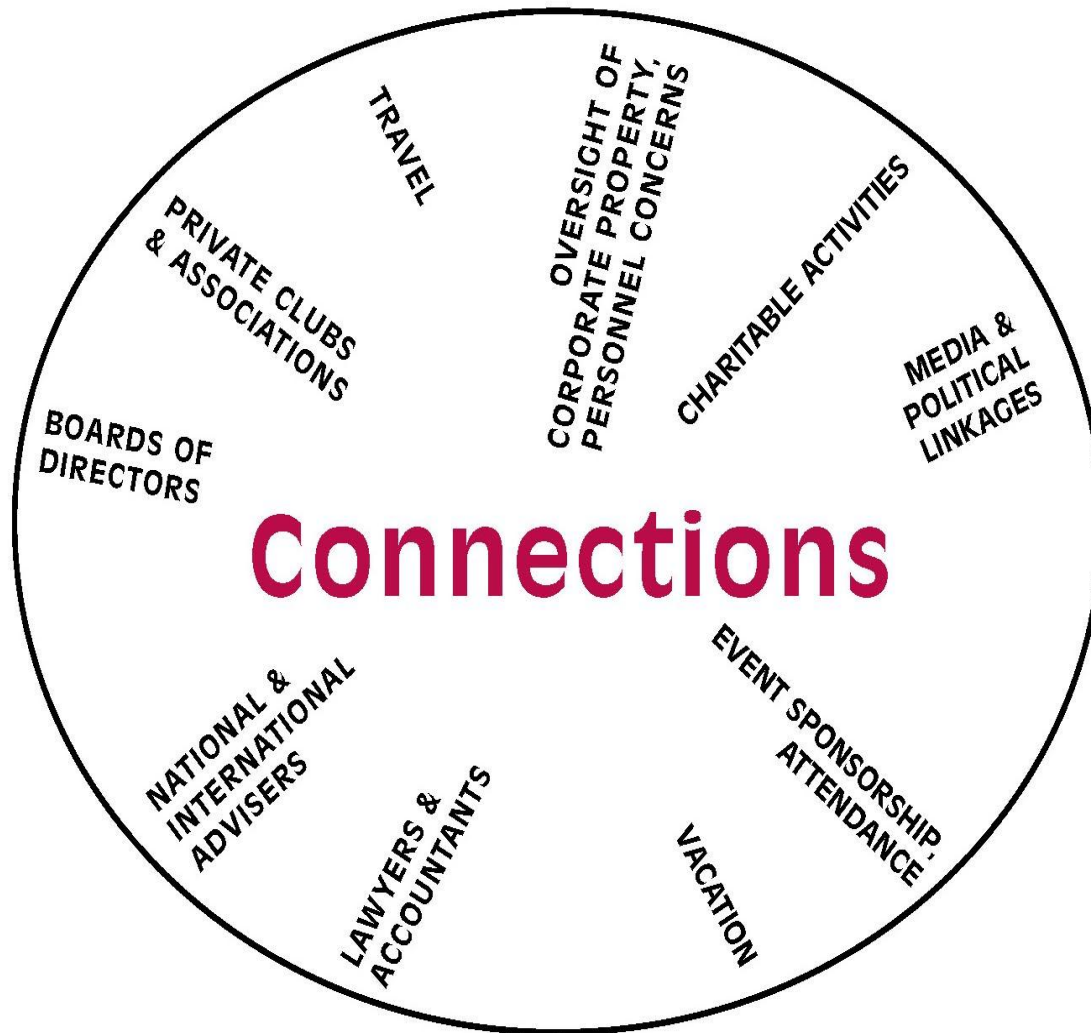
Mental Model for Middle Class



Research done by Ruby K. Payne (2004).

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Mental Model for Wealth



6. Hidden rules about time and money:

Poverty	Middle Class	Wealth
Survival Relationships Entertainment	Work Achievement Material security	Political connections Financial connections Social connections



Hidden Rules for Food

- Poverty – Quantity
 - Are you full? Did you have enough?
- Middle Class – Quality
 - Did you like it? Was it good?
- Wealth – Presentation
 - Was it artistically presented? Did it go with the theme?

**7. We can neither excuse
nor scold students. We
must teach our
students.**



8. We must teach students that there are two sets of rules. Example: Basketball does not have the same rules as football.



“My Mama Says...”

Dr. Rita Pierson

9. To move from poverty to middle class, one must give up (for a period of time) relationships for achievement.



10. Two things that help one move out of poverty are:

- **Education**
- **Relationships**



- # **11. Four reasons one leaves poverty are:**
- Too painful to stay**
 - Vision or goal**
 - Key relationship**
 - Special talent/skill**



12. What is the motivation for learning?





*"No significant
learning occurs
without a
significant
relationship."*

–Dr. James Comer

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13. Mutual respect is:

- **High expectations**
- **Insistence**
- **Support**



Fostering Student Engagement

What can teachers do to foster student engagement and create positive peer culture?

“When working with kids who come from difficult backgrounds ... you’ve really got to understand these kids. You’ve got to understand what they don’t understand and what their misunderstandings are, and you’ve got to have the confidence to say, ‘If these children tell me what they are thinking, I can clear up any confusions that they have.’”

–Ronald Ferguson